

CONTRARY TO LONG TRADITION, INDIA'S BOWLING UNIT EMERGED AS THE STRONGER SUIT OF THE CAMPAIGN. EACH BOWLER HAD A DEFINED ROLE, BUT FLEXIBILITY WAS THE KEY

overs; Kuldeep Yadav, whose loop, dip, turn and varying lines frequently had batsmen floundering, was tasked with picking wickets in a cluster; Hardik and Jadeja were reserved for neutralising the middle order; while Axar Patel was the floater who could be bowled at any stage of the match to upset the rhythm of the opposition. And above everyone else, there was Jasprit Bumrah, the show-stopper. Best thing since sliced bread.

Every time the 30-year-old pacer had the ball in his hand, Indian fans were seized by a quite unfamiliar confidence. Pakistan needed 40 off 36 balls, but India were deemed to have a chance of winning, because 12 of those 36 balls would be bowled by Bumrah. South Africa needed 30 off 30, but they clung on to a sliver of hope as 12 out of the 30 balls belonged to the pace spearhead. For Indian cricket, this was uncharted territory, where pundits and fans were reposing more confidence in Bumrah's magical abilities than Kohli, Rohit and SKY's sublime wielding of the willow. So pervasive was this feeling that the joke going around in the West Indies was that India were cheating: while Rohit and Co. got to bat their full quota of 20 overs, every other team that played against India only got 16 overs to bat, since Bumrah's four didn't yield anything.

The Gujarat-born pacer wasn't even the highest wicket-taker of the tournament, but such was his impact with the ball that he was the unanimous choice for the Player of the Tournament award. In fact, it wasn't so much the wickets as his frugality that induced jaw-dropping reactions—an economy of 4.17 in an era where eight-nine runs an over is the acceptable norm. The placard that Mohammed Siraj carried at the culmination of the finals in Barbados described it best: 'Bumrah is the best bowler on land, sea and air'.

CARRIBEAN REDEMPTION

As the Indian team hit all the right notes through their campaign to emerge as champions, the conductor of this orchestra chose to stay behind the scenes. Just as only Rahul Dravid could. Just as he had during his playing career. Even a well-meaning social media campaign urging the team to win the title for their coach failed to arouse his emotions. "I don't believe in doing it for somebody, it is against my values. Why does a mountaineer want to climb Mount Everest? Because it's there. Similarly, why do we want to win the World Cup? Because it's there," is how the coach reacted when asked to comment on the #DoItForDravid campaign.

He would eventually express himself—and let out an exultant cry while holding the World Cup trophy in his hand—but only when the job was done. At that moment, one couldn't help but think of the year 2007. It was the same Caribbean islands where India crashed to a first-round exit at the 50-over World Cup under Dravid's captaincy. At the time, the skipper couldn't help but shed a tear or two. It was to become one of the lowest points in Indian cricket and would eventually lead to Dravid giving up the captaincy.

"I was lucky that this bunch of boys made it possible for me to be able to win this trophy...," the Indian coach said on the sidelines after the win. "I am not a legacy person. I just feel glad that we gave it the best we could." When his team tossed him up the air in celebration, life seemed to have come a full circle for Rahul Dravid.

And so, under the Barbadian sun, all the different strands of planning, preparation and execution that went into India's commanding performances materialised in a sleek silver trophy and in soul-stirring, regenerative joy. ■